

Online Education Resource Management

'Google' type search for the internal knowledge base

When an institute's own knowledge repository is available online, it is not necessarily provided with the search facility. Browsing the dissertations, for example, organised as per the year of submission, does not help the user to quickly locate the one needed. If at all the search facility is provided, it searches only through the metadata such as author names, year of submission and perhaps a few keywords. It doesn't happen to be rich enough to make search return the most relevant results. There is a need to provide 'google' type search for the internal knowledge base, which consists of MS-Office and PDF documents along with webpages.

Fortunately, tools are available to do 'full-text' search across the internal document repository. Some of them are available either freely or at low cost. Typically called 'Enterprise Search' tools, they can be either used as out-of-box or programmed to customise as per an institute's requirements.



Shrikant Mulik
lead consultant,
L&T Infotech

Harnessing Web and Mobile Technology

Online sports and fitness analyser

IndiaKheLo creates sports and physical fitness portfolio for each student on its online portal. This portfolio keeps a complete track of the student's activities outside his classroom in the playground. The sports and fitness analyser by IndiaKheLo is specially designed to cater to the needs of students in educational institutions. Parents are regularly updated using e-mails and SMS about their wards' performance in the school. Schools can also use this technology to generate sports and fitness report card which is equivalent to their academic report card. IndiaKheLo also uses its Web portal for talent scouting and linking talented players with sports associations and corporates.



Vaibhav Tandon
co-founder and
business head,
IndiaKheLo.com

Different pedagogies integrated at GEMS!

GEMS Schools use technology to experiment with a variety of pedagogical approaches designed to meet the needs of all learners. The Internet is used not only for providing interesting, diverse and current learning materials, images, sound and text but teachers also use free homepage startup sites to create their own webpages, post assignments and create study guides which include images, audio and hyperlinks. Podcasting is fast catching up. Virtual field trips to online museums, simulations, computerised data logging using scientific probes and virtual laboratory experiments bridge the gap between scientific and informal knowledge. Simulation offers a somewhat risk-free environment and is economically viable.



Ruby Kumar
assistant director-
education,
Global Education
Management Systems
(GEMS) Schools

Screen-reading software for the visually impaired

Screen reading software like JAWS and NVDA are used nowadays to read out aloud the contents on the screen to visually impaired people, thus making them an active participant in e-learning. Sometimes refreshable braille displays are also used to assist visually impaired people. However, these are a bit expensive.

Entire courses like MIT OpenCourseWare and Opera Web Standards Curriculum are being provided online for free under creative commons licences, which means colleges or institutions can take parts of the course and include it in their own syllabi. I foresee teachers using technologies like Opera Unite to conduct lessons or exams with students at peer-to-peer level without uploading any content onto a central server.



Shwetank Dixit
Web evangelist,
Opera Software

Knowledge sharing on the lines of Web 2.0

Rapid emergence of Web 2.0 is changing the way knowledge is created, shared and institutionalised. There are few examples of educational institutions adopting Web 2.0 strategically. In one such implementation, the institute has adopted a hybrid approach of relying on externally hosted applications and internally built knowledge portal with integration between the two. The portal has many collaborative features like blogs, wikis, discussion forums and expert finder, and an in-built security mechanism that allows external stakeholders to access relevant sections and be part of the innovation ecosystem. They get engaged in providing inputs for making the curriculum relevant, generating real-life case studies, peer reviews, collaboration on research and consulting work and thereby enriching the entire learning and output of the institute.



Dhiraaj Sinha
head of Technology
Group, Applications
Solutions, Perot
Systems